The Mihai Eminescu Trust

NEWSLETTER 2013

THE TRUST'S WORK IN 2013

This year's highlights have been two-fold: the first ever Transylvanian Literary Festival in Richiș and the planting of the Trust's millionth sapling tree.The Book Festival from 5th to 9th September brought authors from Britain and Continental Europe into Transylvania. Stars included the historian Roy Foster and the biographer Artemis Cooper, as well as two Saxon authors, Johann Schaas, and Sarah Dootz (who have always remained in their own villages, farming and guarding their churches and who in 2013 published books on the Saxons' traditions, history and centuries old way of life).

Other authors with knowledge of the area including Tony Scotland and William Blacker also spoke, and participants toured the area, meeting members of the local community. James Knox, author of 'Robert Byron - a Biography', held a subversive fringe meeting in a Richiș hay field on the topic "Does travel writing have a future?". Lucy Abel-Smith, who organised the Festival from start to finish, said afterwards *"But for the Mihai Eminescu Trust this event could never have taken place ; the Trust's restoration of Richiș's huge classical village hall, the guest house accommodation and the restoration work in close-by villages grounded the 5 days of work and pleasure".*



In May in the hills between Archita and Roadeș, HRH the Prince of Wales, together with MET vice-president Caroline Fernolend, planted the millionth tree for the MET. The 'Plant for the Planet' programme, supported by the world-wide hotel chain Accor, was started by the Trust in 2009, under the name of "A Forest for Each School". The project aims at restoring degraded forests and areas affected by excessive deforestation in Transylvania. At the same time, this project raises young people's awareness of 'their forests' and of the importance of the natural habitat. Between autumn 2009 and spring 2013, the MET in collaboration with 70 schools, 56 Town Halls and Forest Associations and 15 Forestry Authorities, planted 1,124,325 saplings in 5 Romanian counties (Brașov, Covasna, Harghita, Mureș and Sibiu). This programme is of high importance, not only for improving the climate and landscape of Transylvania, but also for providing income for rural communities. The Accor "Plant for the Planet" programme will continue this year (coordinated by the French organisation Pur Projet) under the name "Plant for the Future".

JANUARY

LONDON LAUNCH: FRIENDS OF MET

A celebration dinner for 25 years' work in Romania was held at the Romanian Embassy in January and two months later the MET launched FRIENDS of the Trust there. Sir Simon Jenkins, Chairman of the National Trust, spoke of the Trust's work as *"The best thought out conservation project I've ever come across"*. In what he described as the most remarkable conservation challenge in the whole of Europe, he said *"I cannot speak too highly of what's happened in*

these valleys, in these hills, in these villages and in these towns..." The Romanian Ambassador, His Excellency Dr Ion Jinga, said: *"The MET's work is used now as a model for new rural regeneration projects, not only in Romania, but in other parts of Europe."* In welcoming new friends, MET Chairman Jessica Douglas-Home said *"anybody who supports us in any way will be continuing the work we've done"*.

FEBRUARY

LONG-TERM PARTNERSHIP WITH BABEȘ-BOLYAI UNIVERSITY IN CLUJ-NAPOCA

While students keep coming on an annual basis for "hands-on classes" to the Transylvanian villages, where MET is working together with the local communities, this year we organised an exhibition-workshop at the Babeș-Bolyai University, where professors and students participated in a lively debate about the MET's work, and the importance of heritage protection. Last summer one of the Babeș-Bolyai students chose the village of Alma Vii for his master thesis. He sought to identify in tandem with the local community "the best possible strategy for valuing the natural and cultural heritage".

HERITAGE PLATFORM WITH MET, HERITAS AND ASTRA MUSEUM, SIBIU

In November 2012, during a workshop in Sibiu, the idea came of creating a "Heritage platform" together with public and non-governmental organisations active in the preservation of the natural and cultural heritage of Romania. 27 organisations have joined up to share experiences and work together for a common goal.

MARCH

INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE WITH BUCHAREST ACADEMY OF ECONOMIC SCIENCE

Based on a multitude of village projects over 12 years of activity, the MET has created an integrated approach to the revitalisation of the region's heritage, aiming at inspiring rural communities and improving their livelihood through sensitive exploitation of their rich and varied culture. The MET team, together with carefully chosen specialists has evaluated the 1,100 projects completed so far, and has organised a series of seminars and conferences to draw lessons from these achievement. The project concluded with the international conference in Bucharest that focused on promoting partnerships between public, private and non-governmental players, at National and European level, to bring about long-term cultural, social and economic initiatives in rural areas.

APRIL

WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT IN CRIȚ

Criț was one of the first villages, where the Whole Village Project was put into practice and has proved a good example of villagers using their ancient heritage to great effect. This year, with the help of the Trust, Criț craftsmen and guesthouse ladies have restored and renovated houses and installed wooden shutters: No 177, No 170, No 22, No 88.

MAY

THE FORTIFIED CHURCH IN ARCHITA

Since the Trust completed the emergency repairs in Archita church last year, we have received a grant for the urgent and more substantial work (not covered in the EU Leistelle European grant). A team of workmen were trained on site and materials were provided to restore the church's fortification walls and towers, as well as repairing and replacing roofs on the first and second defence walls. The team also started rendering another exterior wall. Work will continue next year on rendering more sections.

Thanks to the training programme in several other villages over the last few years, the Architan craftsmen have gained more confidence in their skills and are now available for employment by the Mayor and private house owners.

JUNE

SUSTAINABLE AGRICULTURE IN REMOTE AREAS OF ROMANIA

The Mihai Eminescu Trust and the America Swiss Foundation SAVE have signed up to work together for two years in Mălâncrav village in the Laslea commune.The work will consist of identifying and saving ancient Transylvanian fruit and nut trees, creating a nursery of local varieties and further restoring the orchard itself.

CRAFTSMEN TRAINING IN STEJĂRENI

Colin Richards, Historic Environment Manager for Shropshire Council, and his team have been coming twice a year for many years to Romania to help the MET train local craftsmen in the use of traditional materials and techniques. This year, in the small 600-strong village of Stejăreni, 6 young men

were selected to take part in a training programme. This Spring we hope our application for a grant to restore the old village school will come through and we can take on more local craftsmen for further training on this important village building.

JULY

VISIT BY CLUB OF ROME GENERAL SECRETARY

Liviu Tudor, general secretary of the Romanian Association for the Club of Rome visited the MET in the Sighisoara citadel to learn more about the Trust's work. He then travelled to Mălâncrav to see the Apafi Manor, all the Trust's restored houses in the village, and the fortified church. A partnership agreement between Fundația Tudor and MET was signed for the restoration of two houses in Maramureș and for the Butchers' Tower in Sighișoara citadel, a UNESCO World Heritage site.

CULTURAL WEEK IN BUNESTI COMMUNE

The day before the re-consecration of the Criț Lutheran church, a brunch of delicious food, cooked by the villagers using produce from their gardens, took place in the courtyard of the MET guesthouse, Criț No 217. The Trust also held an exhibition of its conservation work. Caroline Fernolend (MET director) spoke to a large group of guests from all over Romania including Mr Peter Maffay and Mr Schmidt (Cultural Week, Germany). She emphasised the Trust's approach to the preservation of Transylvania's heritage giving examples of malpractice.

VILLAGE SURVEY COLLABORATION WITH BUCHAREST UNIVERSITY

The purpose of the project has been to create a strategy for future developments in the villages of Criț, Florești and Archita, based on the information collected during the survey. The aim is for the mayor and council and village residents to have access to this information and be able to monitor the state of the historic buildings and carefully plan any further building or significant changes.

At the same time, by visiting each property and approaching the owners, the Trust aims to increase the villagers' awareness of the value of their traditional heritage - one of the MET's central goals. The project began with the Trust selecting eleven students to attend a workshop in Criț, 15th - 24th of July, in collaboration with the University of Architecture and Urbanism, Ion Mincu, in Bucharest.

AUGUST

MĂLÂNCRAV BRICK KILN OPENING

Colin Richards, visited Malancrav in June to instruct the village team in the process of firing in the new kiln. He visited again on 13th August and found the results excellent. In his dispatch, Colin wrote: *"the bricks were some of the best I have seen in Romania...when tapped together they rang like a bell"*. Regular production will now begin with the firing of both bricks and tiles when a consignment is needed. A training film based on the team's work over the past few months, with descriptions both in English and in Romanian, was completed in September.

RICHIȘ COMMUNITY HALL

Local building entrepreneur Rareș Dudas and a dozen volunteers from Richiș helped carry out reconstruction on their large 19th century Hall in the heart of the village. Massive repair work on the roof and on the exterior and interior was completed during the year - just in time for the Transylvanian Book Festival. The hall is now in use for public meetings, weddings, christenings and funerals, as well as for kindergarten and school children. After many years of frustrating delays, the enthusiasm of the village for saving this building, which is vital for the future of the community, was a heart-warming example of the galvanising effect of the MET's Whole Village concept.

During the year, Herr Schaas, village guide, church guardian and one of the 6 Saxons remaining in Richiș, was interviewed extensively by MET's senior guesthouse manager Andrea Rost. His stories of life in Saxon Transylvanian before and after World War 11, charmingly and wisely described, have now been published in *"Das Leben ist so schon, wenn man daruber lacheln kann!"*. A discussion on the book took place in September during the Book Festival in Richiș, and also at the Saxon annual reunion in Sighișoara.

SEPTEMBER

PHOTOGRAPHY COMPETITION

Following the success of the "Plant for the Planet" project in Plăieșii de Jos, the local community having heard of the Trust's village work in other regions) asked for further help in protecting their local Sekler-Hungarian heritage. After several meetings with the villagers, the MET team suggested the best way

to explain to the community the value of the architectural heritage would be for the MET to organize a photography contest for the young generation and in this way show the built and natural heritage and traditions through the eyes of the young. The contest proved to be a success with 30 participants exhibiting in the village hall, along with a traditional dance festival.

OCTOBER

ADRIAN URSU TV INTERVIEW WITH MET CHAIRMAN

In an extensive televised interview, on the 17th of October, the well-known Romanian political analyst and TV presenter Adrian Ursu talked to Jessica Douglas-Home, who first discovered her love for Romania in the time of Communism.

NOVEMBER

CONSERVATION AND ADDING VALUE TO FRUIT VARIETIES

An inventory aiming to record ancient Transylvanian fruit varieties began during the Autumn. 60 local farmers, from 29 villages took on the task and Swiss and Romanian experts attended a workshop where a list of 69 fruit species were submitted. The result was that 37 varieties (including apple, pears, walnuts and quince) were identified, 17 fruit varieties recorded but not identified, and 14 apple varieties will be further investigated.

PUBLIC SIGNBOARDS IN BUNEŞTI

The idea of improving signs emerged during a community annual meeting. Participants suggested less garish and more appropriate designs for the landscape and to use only local material and labour. The idea was presented to the local authorities, who offered their support for the project and covered the cost for the materials.

DECEMBER

WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT:

Ms Rovana Plumb, Romania's Minister for Environment and Climate Change and the Mihai Eminescu Trust's Chairman Jessica Douglas-Home signed in London a cooperation agreement on environmental protection and sustainable development in the rural areas of Romania. The agreement concentrates on the potential for the wider adoption of ecological sewage instillations across Romania, following the hugely successful implementation of the Mihai Eminescu Trust's award winning scheme in Viscri. The Ministry acknowledged with appreciation the high quality of the MET's work over the years, particularly in the rural areas of Transylvania.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The projects described above are only a selection of the highlight from the 34 projects completed during 2013.

The Horizon Foundation provided funding and sponsorship for a total of 9 projects in 2013 for which we are most grateful.

We thank all those who joined Friends of the MET, and for the generous donations from Nicholas Allen, Alice and Simon Boyd, Marcia Brocklebank, Max Egremont, JoJo and Jonathan Hull, Simon Keswick, Rodney Leach, Daniel Lloyd, Jon Moynihan, Richard Nissen, Andrew Popper, Henrietta St George and Percy Weatherall; and for the Forderverein-Lions Club Kitzingen, Stiftung Gutes mit Schönem Verbinden, Pas de Calais - France, Ottobrunn - Bayern, Anna Wenzel and Karl Haist for their grants.

After 14 years during which the MET has successfully completed over 1,200 projects and has become recognised as Romania's leading heritage conservation and restoration foundation, HRH the Prince of Wales is retiring from his role as a patron. This coincides with his increasing assumption of Royal duties and with the transfer to Romania of responsibility for all the MET's operations, the culmination of years of preparation by the Trustees for local self-sufficiency. We take this occasion to express our gratitude to HRH for his past contributions and our pleasure that amidst his many other concerns he has said he will find time to continue helping the MET and those like us who are working to revive the beautiful region of Transylvania.

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any offering to either of our offices. Over its first 12 years the MET benefited from the remarkable generosity of the Packard Humanities Institute. Their programme of giving came to a conclusion two years ago so, in order to continue with our restoration projects we must look elsewhere for our fund raising, which makes every grant or donation all the more valuable.

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